"And they went to your head right away, didn't they?"

It rather took my breath away that even an officer could imagine that corporal's stripes would make me proud in themselves, but I just said, "I'm sorry, sir."

He then proceeded to chew me out in true captainly fashion. (Officers are given a six-week course on outchewing and a six-minute course on military strategy.)

I was certain that I would be broken to private after twenty-four hours as a corporal and I was even revolving methods of explaining this to Gertrude—but the captain wore himself out with the expulsion of sufficient steam and decided to take no further action.

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If he had broken me it would have made very little difference, for on July 18, 1946, two months and five days after Gertrude's letter had initiated the whole thing, I got the news that my discharge was approved. My little speech, I suppose, had done the trick.

I began at once to prepare for shipping out to Fort Meade, the place that had been my home in my first week as a soldier.

While doing so, I attended the first wedding in my life on Saturday, July 20, and did so in almost civilian effervescence. I was warned that at the reception there would be a lot of gentle old women who would not appreciate my notions of humor and that I must be very quiet. I promised and, on the whole, behaved myself until the bride-to-be fanned herself and said that, really, now that the whole thing was soon to be over, she didn't see what the excitement was about.

"Really?" I said. "Wait till tonight."

And I was promptly dragged out as unfit for genteel company.

That night I was taken to the noncommissioned officers' club and encouraged to drink. I was only too glad to do so because I was feeling hilarious. I grew even more hilarious after a few drinks and came to be incapable of walking in any trustworthy fashion. I had to be escorted to the latrine twice (though I do believe I was still capable of unzipping on my own) and then had to be carefully put to bed, as on the night of the Seder three months before.